

ROYALE ISLES LANKA

UX / UI Design System

Brand Style Guide

Experience Architecture

How to Use This Document

This document serves three purposes simultaneously. It is a brand philosophy, a practical design system, and a product vision framework. All three must be read together.

The brand philosophy explains what Royale Isles Lanka believes and why every design decision is made in service of a specific kind of traveller. The design system translates those beliefs into implementable specifications. The product vision framework describes the full experience arc from a traveller's first visit to their post-trip storytelling.

When a design decision is difficult, return to the principles. When a development choice is made under time pressure, apply the specifications. When a photograph is being selected, measure it against the imagery hierarchy. When a sentence is being written, hold it against the voice guidelines.

"The question that governs every decision: does this serve the traveller before it serves anything else?"

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01 · Brand Philosophy

1.1 The Origin of Royale Isles Lanka

Most travel platforms are built around transactions. They are designed to convert curiosity into clicks, clicks into bookings, and bookings into revenue. Every word, every image, every interaction serves a single commercial purpose: to move the visitor toward a purchase as efficiently as possible.

Royale Isles Lanka was built from a different belief entirely. Not the belief that a destination has been underserved, but the belief that a particular kind of traveller has been.

Somewhere in the world, there is someone who has stayed in the finest hotels on several continents and felt, quietly and persistently, that something was still missing. Who travels not for novelty but for meaning. Who is tired of platforms that sell them an experience when what they are looking for cannot be packaged. Who does not need another beautifully photographed destination. They need to feel understood.

"A platform built not for a destination, but for a particular kind of traveller. One who has always known that the most important journeys are the ones that change something."

1.2 The Five Pillars

The experience of Royale Isles Lanka is built on five beliefs. They are not separate ideas but a single cohesive philosophy expressed in five dimensions. Every design decision, every line of copy, every interaction is shaped by one question: what does it feel like to be inside this platform?

Elegant	Elegance is not a visual style. It is a discipline. It is the result of making careful decisions and then removing everything that does not earn its place. The elegant platform shows less than it knows, says less than it could, and trusts the traveller to feel the depth behind the restraint.
Private	The traveller is a guest, not a data point. Privacy is the most undervalued quality in digital design and the most valued quality in luxury hospitality. No aggressive data capture, no pop-ups, no visible tracking behaviour. Personalisation should feel like being remembered by someone who cares, not monitored by a system that wants something.
Sophisticated	Depth over display. Trusting the traveller's intelligence means not explaining what a photograph already communicates, not adding an adjective where the noun is sufficient, not filling silence with information simply because the space exists.

Personal	A platform that listens before it speaks. The deepest form of luxury is being genuinely understood, not categorised or targeted. The traveller who feels understood does not compare prices. They simply know they are in the right place.
Experience	Every touchpoint is part of the journey. The act of exploring this platform is itself a luxury experience. Before a traveller has made an inquiry, the time they have spent inside Royale Isles Lanka should have given them something real: a feeling, a desire, a clearer sense of what they are looking for.

1.3 The Design North Star

"Every decision made in design, in writing, in technology, and in communication should serve a single person: the traveller who is searching for something they cannot quite name yet, who needs to feel, before they have taken a single step, that someone who understands them is already ready to walk alongside them."

This statement governs every design review, every copy edit, and every development decision. A feature that is technically impressive but creates friction fails this test. Copy that is commercially effective but feels pressuring fails this test. An image that is visually striking but emotionally empty fails this test.

1.4 The Traveller We Serve

The traveller Royale Isles Lanka serves cannot be described in demographics. Age, income, and nationality are the wrong coordinates. The right coordinates are psychological.

PORTRAIT OF THE TRAVELLER

This is someone who has travelled enough to know the difference between a good trip and a meaningful one. Who has sat in beautiful hotel rooms and felt, inexplicably, that something was missing. Who makes travel decisions slowly, privately, and with considerable care. Who finds most travel websites exhausting: too much information offered too quickly, too little understanding of what they are actually looking for. They value privacy, not just physical privacy but the privacy of their deliberation. They carry a quiet concern about any unfamiliar destination: not fear, but the hesitation that comes from not knowing anyone who has been. What they need is not a sales pitch. What they need is a voice they trust, telling them something true.

1.4.1 Three Primary Traveller Personas

Oliver Bennett: The Thoughtful Explorer	Seeks meaningful experiences, personal discovery, and authentic cultural connections. Researches carefully. Responds to editorial depth and specific knowledge. Distrusts promotional language. Needs to feel that what he is reading comes from someone who has genuinely been there.
Charlotte Sinclair: The Luxury Seeker	Values trust, comfort, privacy, and highly personalised service. Expects every detail to have been considered. Responds to restraint and quality signals. Will not be rushed. The quality of the consultation experience is as important as the destination itself.
Amelia Carter: The Slow Traveller	Prioritises immersion, connection, and a deeper understanding of places and communities. Reads slowly and deeply. Wants to spend time with content. Responds to atmosphere and emotional storytelling. Measures value in experience, not efficiency.

02 · Design Principles

These are not interface guidelines. They are the values that sit behind every navigation decision, every interaction design choice, every content flow. When a decision is difficult and the right answer is not immediately obvious, these principles are the authority.

Principle I: Guide, Do Not Overwhelm

The platform always knows more than it shows. Its role is to select, sequence, and reveal in a way that feels guided rather than deposited. Three outstanding options over thirty adequate ones.

- Content arrives when it is relevant, not all at once
- Fewer, better choices always outperform comprehensive lists
- The art of this platform is knowing what to show next

Principle II: Story Before Detail

Every piece of content leads with its emotional truth before its factual content. The feeling of being somewhere before the description of what is there. Emotional copy earns the right to deliver practical information.

- Imagery creates atmosphere before photography documents
- Every page has a narrative arc, not just an information hierarchy
- Practical details follow naturally from an established emotional context

Principle III: Trust Before Conversion

The platform never asks for anything before it has given something. The first impression is not a form. The first scroll is not an interruption. Trust is earned through quality, honesty, and patience.

- No inquiry prompt appears in the first scroll of any page
- No scarcity language, countdown timers, or urgency of any kind
- Every interaction invites. None directs.

Principle IV: Human Before Technology

The AI assistant, the recommendation engine, and the personalisation flows are tools, not the brand's identity. Technology makes human attentiveness more accessible and more precisely attuned. It does not replace human judgment.

- The AI assistant speaks in the same voice as the platform, never robotic, never clinical
- Personalisation feels like being remembered by someone who cares
- Automation assists. Humans decide.

Principle V: Calm Over Urgency

There is no urgency in the Royale Isles Lanka experience. No countdown timers. No scarcity language. No pressure of any kind. Calm is both an aesthetic and an ethical choice: the belief that the traveller's deliberation is sacred.

- No "Book Now" buttons, "Limited Availability" banners, or urgency-based calls to action
- Calls to action are always invitations: "Begin Your Journey", "Tell Us How You Like to Travel"
- Loading states and transitions breathe. They never rush.

Principle VI: Inclusion as a Luxury Value

Accessibility is not compliance. It is the expression of the belief that an exceptional experience should be available to everyone who seeks it. WCAG AA is the minimum standard, never the ceiling.

- Colour contrast, keyboard navigability, readable text at every scale
- Alt text written with the same care as visible copy
- Accessibility decisions are UX decisions. They are not a separate conversation.

Principle VII: Attention as a Gift

The traveller's attention is the most valuable thing they can offer. It is never wasted. Every image rewards sustained looking. Every sentence rewards reading to the end. Every transition rewards patience.

- Every sentence earns its place. Edit until only what matters remains.
- Every image contains a depth the eye continues to explore
- Every transition is felt, never merely seen

03 · Colour System

The palette was not assembled. It was composed, in the same way that a room is composed: each element chosen for the emotional quality it contributes to the traveller's experience of being inside it.

" The palette is not a collection of colours. It is a composed atmosphere. Change one proportion, and you change the feeling of the entire room."

3.1 The 60-20-10-5-3-2 System

This allocation follows the logic of the classic 60-30-10 interior design principle, extended into a six-colour digital system. The percentages protect each other. **Gold at 10% is decorative. Gold at 2% is a private mark of quality (SEE THE DIFFERENCE).**

Swatch	Name and Hex	Emotional Role	%	Usage
#FBF9F5	Warm Ivory Silk	The Canvas: emotional warmth and breathing room	60%	Page backgrounds
#004225	British Racing Green	The Anchor: heritage authority and quiet prestige	20%	Headers, nav, accents
#1A1A1A	Charcoal Black	The Ink: editorial readability and sustained comfort	10%	All body text
#E8E1D5	Soft Stone	The Texture: material depth and tactile layering	5%	Card backgrounds
#0D1F17	Deep Forest Shadow	The Atmosphere: cinematic drama and intensity	3%	Hero sections only
#C5A059	Satin Brass Gold	The Jewellery: rarity, value, private distinction	2%	Accents, dividers

3.2 Colour Profiles

British Racing Green: #004225

The primary brand colour. It slows the emotional pace of everything it touches. It signals that there is no urgency here, no commercial pressure, no reason to make a quick decision. In UX research,

deep greens in luxury interfaces consistently increase time-on-page and reduce the perception of commercial intent.

- Heritage associations: Bentley, Aston Martin, private members' clubs, country estate libraries
- Sri Lankan resonance: the deep permanent green of Nuwara Eliya, the Knuckles Range, the tea highlands
- Use for: navigation, primary buttons, section backgrounds, headings, icon fills, divider lines, focus indicators

Warm Ivory Silk: #FBF9F5

The background the traveller lives inside. Not white. Pure white (#FFFFFF) is the colour of a hospital corridor. Warm Ivory Silk carries the warmth of fine linen. It makes the interface feel settled rather than stark, photography look richer, and negative space feel like breathing room rather than emptiness.

- Use for: all page backgrounds, card backgrounds, text overlays on dark hero sections

Charcoal Black: #1A1A1A

Body text uses Charcoal Black rather than pure black (#000000). Pure black on a warm ivory background creates maximum contrast, which produces visual fatigue during extended reading. Charcoal Black at #1A1A1A sits at exactly the point where readability is fully preserved and visual tension is removed.

- Use for: all body copy, captions, form labels, UI text, metadata

Satin Brass Gold: #C5A059

The jewellery of the palette. Present rarely, and therefore meaningful every time. It does not shine. It glows. The colour of a well-worn Rolex, a private invitation embossed in foil, or aged brasswork on a door that has been there for two hundred years.

CRITICAL ACCESSIBILITY RULE

Gold on British Racing Green (#004225) achieves only 2.9:1 contrast ratio, which is below WCAG AA for text. Gold must never carry essential text on dark green surfaces. Use gold exclusively for: decorative dividers, icon accents, border highlights, and non-text UI elements.

3.3 Accessibility Contrast Matrix

Charcoal on Ivory Silk	12.6:1 · WCAG AAA · Primary body text pairing
British Racing Green on Ivory	9.8:1 · WCAG AAA · Headings and display text
White on British Racing Green	9.8:1 · WCAG AAA · Navigation, buttons, banners

Charcoal on Soft Stone	10.4:1 · WCAG AAA · Card content and labels
White on Deep Forest Shadow	18.1:1 · WCAG AAA · Hero sections and cinematic overlays
Satin Brass Gold on Green	2.9:1 · DECORATIVE ONLY · Never for essential text

3.4 Colour Rules

- Never use pure black (#000000). Use Charcoal Black #1A1A1A.
- Never use pure white (#FFFFFF) as a page background. Use Warm Ivory Silk.
- Never introduce a seventh colour without explicit design system approval.
- Never apply British Racing Green at above 20% of any interface screen.
- Never use Satin Brass Gold as a text colour on dark surfaces.
- Never use Deep Forest Shadow for anything other than cinematic hero sections.

04 · Typography

Typography is the most intimate visual decision a brand makes. For the traveller reading this platform, the letterform is the first quality signal they receive before a single word carries its meaning.

4.1 Playfair Display: The Editorial Voice

Selected as the primary display typeface because it carries, in its letterforms alone, precisely the qualities the brand is built around: a high-contrast serif with classical proportions that communicates refinement, editorial depth, and timeless elegance without coldness or distance. Its italic is particularly expressive, generous, slightly inclined, with the quality of handwritten thought translated into fine typography. When a pull quote is set in Playfair Display italic, it does not merely present words. It gives them a particular emotional inflection.

USAGE

All H1 headlines · Major section titles · Pull quotes and editorial callouts · The brand logotype · Chapter and section openers. Minimum size: 20px regular weight, 18px bold. Never use Playfair Display for body text or UI labels below 20px. The high-contrast strokes become unreadable at small sizes.

4.2 Inter: The Clarity Voice

Designed specifically for digital interfaces, Inter's letterforms are optimised for readability at every size across every device. Where Playfair Display carries emotional weight, Inter carries clarity. It disappears into the reading experience. The reader feels the content, not the typeface carrying it.

USAGE

All body text · Navigation labels · Form fields and labels · Button text · Captions · All UI microcopy · Error messages · Metadata. Minimum size: 14px for labels and captions, 16px for body text, 18px for long-form reading.

4.3 Type Scale

Display XL

Playfair Display · 72px / Bold · Hero headlines only

Display L	Playfair Display · 56px / 700 · Section openers
H1	Playfair Display · 48px / 700 · Page titles
H2	Playfair Display · 36px / 600 · Section headings
H3	Playfair Display · 28px / 600 · Subsection headings
H4	Inter · 22px / 600 · Labels and sub-titles
Body Large	Inter · 18px / 400 · Line height 1.7 · Lead paragraphs
Body	Inter · 16px / 400 · Line height 1.7 · All body copy
Caption	Inter · 14px / 400 · Line height 1.5 · Captions, metadata
Label	Inter · 12px / 500 · Tracking +1px · All-caps UI labels
Pull Quote	Playfair Display Italic · 24-32px · Line height 1.5 · Indented with gold border

4.4 Typographic Rules

Line Length

Constrain all body copy to 60-75 characters per line. Content spanning the full width of a wide screen becomes difficult to read. This is an accessibility requirement as much as a readability preference.

Line Height

Body text: minimum 1.7. Long-form reading content: 1.8. Display text: 1.1-1.2. Pull quotes: 1.4-1.5.

Rules

- Never use Playfair Display below 18px
- Never use more than two typefaces in any single layout
- Never use bold for mid-paragraph emphasis. Choose a better word instead.
- All-caps is reserved for labels and micro copy with increased tracking only

05 · Layout & Grid

The layout philosophy of Royale Isles Lanka is built around one conviction: negative space is the most powerful design element available. A page that breathes gives every element within it the room to be felt.

5.1 Grid System

Desktop (1440px and above)

Max content width	1280px, centred
Grid columns	12 columns
Column gutter	24px
Outer margin	80px each side
Section vertical padding	120px top and bottom
Component vertical spacing	48-80px between major components

Tablet (768px to 1199px)

Max content width	Fluid (100% minus 48px)
Grid columns	8 columns
Column gutter	20px
Outer margin	40px each side
Section vertical padding	80px top and bottom

Mobile (320px to 767px)

Max content width	Fluid (100% minus 32px)
Grid columns	4 columns
Column gutter	16px
Outer margin	16px each side
Section vertical padding	60px top and bottom
Touch target minimum	44px by 44px

5.2 Spacing Scale

All spacing follows an 8px base unit system.

4px	Tight inline spacing (icon-to-text gaps)
8px	Tight component internal padding
16px	Standard component padding
24px	Card internal spacing, between-element gaps
40px	Between closely related sections
64px	Between major page sections
96px	Hero and cinematic section padding
160px	Maximum breathing room on full-bleed sections

5.3 Layout Archetypes

The Editorial Spread	Full-width image (60-70vh) with centred text block below. Maximum measure 720px. Used for: hero sections, journal entries, destination openers. No sidebar.
The Cinematic Immersion	Full-bleed image (90-100vh). Text overlay centred with white on Deep Forest Shadow scrim at 30-45% opacity maximum. Used for: homepage hero, section transitions, destination covers.
The Quiet Card	Warm Ivory Silk background for primary cards, Soft Stone for secondary. No drop shadow. Cards are distinguished by background colour, not by elevation. Border radius: 4px only.
The Intimate Two-Column	Left: editorial text (7 columns on desktop). Right: photograph (5 columns). Used for destination sections and experience descriptions. Image height matches text block height.
The Full Bleed Stillness	Reserved for the living photography hero sections only. No UI chrome overlaps the image except the navigation and headline. The image is the room.

5.4 Navigation

The navigation is transparent over hero images and transitions to British Racing Green on scroll or on secondary pages.

- Maximum 5 primary navigation items
- Dropdowns only, with a maximum of 7 items per dropdown. No mega-menus.
- Navigation text: Inter 14px / 500 weight / letter-spacing +0.5px
- Active state: Satin Brass Gold underline 1px
- Mobile: full-screen overlay navigation with generous vertical spacing
- No sticky navigation on mobile

06 · Component Library

6.1 Buttons

Primary CTA	Background: British Racing Green #004225 Text: White #FFFFFF Font: Inter 14px / 500 / tracking +1px / all caps Padding: 16px 40px · Radius: 2px Hover: lightens to #1A5C3A Examples: "Begin Your Journey" · "Tell Us How You Travel"
Secondary CTA	Background: Transparent · Border: 1px solid British Racing Green Text: British Racing Green Hover: fills with British Racing Green, text turns white Examples: "Read More" · "Explore Experiences"
Ghost / Minimal	Text only with Satin Brass Gold underline on hover For in-content links and soft navigation prompts Example: "Continue reading"
Never Use	"Book Now" · "Buy" · "Purchase" · "Click Here" No urgency, no transactional language, no aggressive calls to action All CTAs are invitations, never directives

6.2 Forms and Inquiry

Inquiry forms are the beginning of a conversation, not the activation of a sales funnel. They should feel like being asked a thoughtful question by someone who genuinely wants to understand.

Field Labels	Always visible above the field. Never replaced by placeholder text. Playfair Display italic for the question itself where appropriate. Example: "Tell us a little about the kind of journey you're imagining."
Placeholder Text	Supplementary only. Disappears on focus. Should never carry essential instruction. Tone: warm and conversational. "There's no wrong answer." not "Enter text here."
Validation	Real-time, not on submit. Satin Brass Gold checkmark for completion. Error tone: calm and recovery-oriented. "Something didn't quite work there. No need to start again."
Submit Labels	Never "Submit" or "Send". Use: "Begin the Conversation" · "Share Your Vision" · "Let's Talk"
Progress Indicators	Multi-step forms use a minimal dot indicator (British Racing Green filled, Soft Stone empty). No percentage bars. No "Step 2 of 5" phrasing.

6.3 Cards

Journal / Story Card	Full-bleed image 16:9 · Title: Playfair Display H3 on Ivory · Excerpt: Inter 16px / 1.7 line height / 3 lines maximum · Meta: Inter 13px · Hover: subtle image colour shift, no zoom
Destination Card	Square or 4:3 image · Location name in Playfair Display italic overlay, bottom-left · Brief sensory descriptor: 1 line of Inter 14px · No price, no rating, no star count

Experience Card	Portrait 3:4 image · Category label: Inter 12px / all caps / British Racing Green · Title: Playfair Display 20px · Single sentence hook: Inter 15px italic
Testimonial Card	Soft Stone background · Opening quotation mark: Satin Brass Gold at 48px · Quote text: Playfair Display italic 20px · Attribution: Inter 14px / colour #888888

6.4 Microcopy Reference

Loading	"Something beautiful is coming." / "One moment." No percentage bars or spinning icons alone.
Empty States	"Nothing here yet. But that's often where the best journeys begin."
Errors	"Something didn't quite work there. No need to start again. Let's try a different way."
Confirmation	"Your inquiry has reached us. We're reading it carefully. You'll hear from us shortly."
Success	"That's done. And the good part is only just beginning."
WhatsApp Opening	"Hello, and welcome. We're glad you reached out. Tell us what's on your mind."
Form Opening	"Tell us a little about the kind of journey you're imagining. There's no wrong answer."
404 Page	"This page seems to have found its own quiet path. Let's find yours."

07 · Imagery Direction

Every photograph on this platform is selected on a single criterion: does this create a feeling in the person looking at it before it describes anything? The quality of light through a window before the room it illuminates. The shadow of a passing cloud on a hillside before the hillside itself.

7.1 The Living Photography Concept

The cornerstone of the Royale Isles Lanka visual identity is living photography: still images with micro-animations that create atmosphere without creating urgency. This is a deliberate alternative to cinematic hero video.

WHAT LIVING PHOTOGRAPHY IS

Mist drifting slowly across tea-covered hills. A candle flame moving gently in the stillness. Steam rising from a cup of Ceylon tea on a verandah. Curtains lifting softly in an ocean breeze. The shadow of clouds moving across ancient stone. These are environmental animations: the world breathing, not performing.

WHAT LIVING PHOTOGRAPHY IS NOT

Drone footage sweeping over landscapes. People smiling broadly at the camera. Action sequences, fast cuts between locations. Anything that creates a sense of speed, energy, or the pressure of "so much to see and do". The wrong feeling here is as damaging as no feeling at all.

7.2 Photographic Register

Light

Prefer golden hour and blue hour. Overcast diffused light for interiors and intimate spaces. Never harsh midday sun as a primary compositional element. Light should feel considered, not accidental.

Colour in Photography

Images should naturally harmonise with the brand palette: deep greens, warm ambers, soft stone textures, and dark cinematic backgrounds. Avoid saturated, oversaturated, or HDR-processed images.

Composition

Space and stillness. Empty foreground. The horizon in the upper third, not the centre. Evidence of human presence over direct portraits. A figure in the distance rather than a face close-up. The impression of a person rather than the documentation of one.

7.3 Subject Hierarchy

Tier 1: Atmosphere	Landscape and environment. Tea country, coastline, ancient stone, forest, mist, water. The place before the person. These are the primary emotional carriers of the brand.
Tier 2: Intimacy	The details of experience. A cup of tea. A lantern at dusk. An open book on a verandah. A door into a courtyard. These make the journey feel personal and possible.
Tier 3: Cultural Honesty	Genuine cultural encounters, never staged. A craftsperson at work, hands not face. A fishing village at dawn. A temple corridor at quiet hours. Never tourism photography.
Tier 4: Human Presence	The traveller, always from behind or in silhouette. Facing a view, not the camera. A figure on a train platform. Someone reading on a terrace. The invitation to imagine yourself there.
Never	Stock photography. Smiling faces directed at camera. Destination brochure performances. Group shots. Food photography styled for social media. Drone footage without editorial intent.

7.4 Technical Specifications

Hero / Cinematic	Minimum 2400x1600px · WebP primary, JPEG fallback · Max 800KB · Ratio 3:2 or 16:9
Editorial Cards	Minimum 1200x800px · WebP · Max 300KB · Ratio 3:2 or 4:3
Portrait Cards	Minimum 800x1200px · WebP · Max 300KB · Ratio 2:3
Square Thumbnails	600x600px · WebP · Max 150KB
Colour Profile	sRGB only. No CMYK, no wide-gamut P3.
Compression	Quality 85% JPEG equivalent. Visible grain is acceptable. Blocking artefacts are not.

08 · Motion Design Principles

Motion in Royale Isles Lanka does not perform. It breathes. The difference between a luxury digital experience and a typical digital experience often comes down to how things move, or how they choose, wisely, not to.

8.1 The Living Photography Standard

The homepage hero is the highest-priority motion element. It must be a living photograph: a still image with one environmental micro-movement.

- Slow: 8-20 second loop for atmospheric elements such as mist or steam
 - Environmental: the world moves, not the person
 - Barely perceptible on first viewing
 - Seamlessly looped with no visible cut point
- If the animation is immediately noticed, it is too fast. If it creates a sense of movement, it is too strong. The target perception: "this image feels alive", not "this image is moving."

8.2 Transition Library

Fade In	600ms · ease-out · Use: page sections entering viewport, hero content reveal
Fade Up	700ms · ease-out · Transform: translateY(20px) to 0 · Use: cards, text blocks on scroll
Fade Scale	500ms · ease-out · Scale: 0.97 to 1.0 · Use: modal and dialog opening
Horizontal Reveal	800ms · ease-in-out · Use: navigation panel, full-screen overlays
Image Parallax	20-30% of scroll speed · Use: editorial image sections only
Living Atmosphere	8-20 second loop · Opacity or transform on pseudo-element overlays · Hero sections only

8.3 Timing Values

Instant	0-100ms · Hover state colour changes, focus indicator appearance
Fast	200ms · Button state transitions, icon state changes
Medium	400-600ms · Component entrance, navigation changes
Slow	700-900ms · Page section reveals, hero content entrance
Atmospheric	8,000-20,000ms · Living photography micro-animation loops

8.4 Reduced Motion

All animations and transitions must respect the prefers-reduced-motion CSS media query. When reduced motion is preferred: fade-only transitions replace all transforms, living photography reverts to a static image, parallax is disabled, and scroll-triggered animations become instant or fade only. This is a WCAG requirement and a care requirement.

8.5 Never Use

- Auto-playing full video as a primary hero element
- Looping background video with visible movement of people
- Transitions faster than 200ms for content blocks
- Bounce, elastic, or spring easing for page transitions
- Parallax greater than 30% scroll rate
- Any animation that plays more than once unless in an explicit atmospheric loop
- Loading spinners. Use fade transitions and skeletal states instead.

09 · Service Philosophy and Business Principles

The way a luxury business behaves is as important as the way it looks. These six principles define how Royale Isles Lanka operates in every client interaction, every consultation, and every internal decision. They are not aspirational values. They are operational commitments.

9.1 Consultation Before Recommendation

Royale Isles Lanka seeks to understand the traveller thoroughly before recommending any destination, itinerary, or experience. A recommendation made without understanding is guesswork. A recommendation made from genuine knowledge of a person's travel history, preferences, pace, and emotional motivations is the foundation of trust.

PHILOSOPHY

The best private travel specialists do not respond to an inquiry with an itinerary. They respond with questions. They learn what the traveller has done before, what worked, what felt incomplete, and what they are genuinely hoping to feel. The itinerary emerges from that conversation, not before it.

PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

Every inquiry receives a personal reply, not a template response. The first response always includes a question, not a proposal. No personalised recommendation is made until at least one full exchange has taken place. AI tools may assist in research and drafting, but every client-facing message is read and approved by a human consultant before sending.

9.2 Fewer, Better Choices

When travellers are presented with too many options, they make worse decisions, experience more anxiety, and feel less confident about the choice they eventually make. This is known in behavioural psychology as the paradox of choice. Royale Isles Lanka resolves this by presenting carefully curated options rather than comprehensive inventories.

PHILOSOPHY

A luxury hotel concierge does not hand a guest a directory of every restaurant in the city. They say: there are two places you should know about tonight. Both are exceptional. Here is the difference between them. The guest leaves the conversation feeling guided, not overwhelmed.

PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

Present a maximum of three destination or experience recommendations at any one time. Use editorial language to distinguish options clearly. Trust the traveller's judgment once they are properly oriented. Avoid "and there's also..." language that adds options after a recommendation has been made.

9.3 Human Judgment Before Automation

AI and automated systems assist the discovery process and help consultants work more efficiently. They do not replace human judgment. The nuance required to understand what a particular traveller will genuinely value, and to present it in a way that resonates specifically with them, belongs to people, not algorithms.

PHILOSOPHY

Technology can surface the right information at the right moment. It cannot know that a traveller who describes themselves as seeking "authenticity" actually means they want to be somewhere that still feels undiscovered, not somewhere that stages cultural performances for visitors. That distinction requires a human conversation.

PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

The AI travel companion assists with discovery and initial research. Every personalised proposal is reviewed and refined by a human consultant. Automated responses are used only for acknowledgement messages, never for recommendations. The consultation stage is always human.

9.4 Trust Before Transaction

Long-term relationships matter more than immediate conversions. A traveller who arrives on this platform, spends time in it, and leaves without making an inquiry has not failed. They may return in six months with complete clarity about what they want and a high level of trust already built. That is a valuable outcome.

PHILOSOPHY

Luxury travel decisions are made slowly. A VVIP traveller may research a destination over several months before reaching out. The platform they return to repeatedly, the one they mention to friends, the one they ultimately trust with a significant life experience, is the one that never pressured them, never reduced their deliberation to a transaction, and was always there when they were ready.

PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

Never follow up more than once after an inquiry without a response. Never use retargeting advertising. Never send marketing emails without explicit permission. Measure success in the quality and depth of relationships, not in the volume of inquiries or conversion rates alone.

9.5 Privacy as a Luxury Value

Traveller information is treated with the same discretion that a private members' club applies to its membership records. Privacy is not a compliance checkbox. It is a demonstration of respect for the traveller as a person rather than as a data point.

PHILOSOPHY

The finest luxury brands do not share, sell, or leverage their clients' personal information. They do not use that information to follow clients around the internet with advertisements. They do not reference personal details in ways that feel intrusive. The traveller who trusts Royale Isles Lanka with details of their travel preferences is offering something private. It is held privately.

PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

No third-party advertising or retargeting tools. No sharing of client data with hotel or experience partners without explicit consent. Minimal data collection: only what is necessary to provide the service. All client communication is stored securely and accessible only to the consultant team. Cookie consent is handled with the most privacy-preserving option as the default.

9.6 Authenticity Over Performance

Sri Lanka is genuinely extraordinary. It does not need to be performed. The experiences Royale Isles Lanka curates should feel natural, unscripted, and true to the place. When an experience begins to feel manufactured for the benefit of a tourist audience, it has already lost what makes it valuable.

PHILOSOPHY

There is a difference between a traveller who walks through a tea plantation alongside a worker who answers their questions honestly, and a traveller who watches a staged demonstration of tea picking designed to photograph well. The first is an experience. The second is a product. Royale Isles Lanka curates experiences, not products.

PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

All recommended experiences are vetted for authenticity before being included in the platform's curated collection. Experiences that have become commercialised or that primarily serve a tourist audience rather than offering genuine cultural access are excluded or clearly contextualised. Partners are chosen for their commitment to genuine hospitality, not for their photography-friendly setups.

How Royale Isles Lanka learns about travellers.
The system that makes personalisation feel personal.

10 · Traveller Discovery Framework

The Traveller Discovery Framework is the system by which Royale Isles Lanka builds an understanding of each traveller's motivations, preferences, and emotional expectations. It is not a form. It is a guided conversation that happens through thoughtful questions, visual choices, and behavioural observation.

"The goal is not to collect data. The goal is to understand a person well enough to serve them honestly."

10.1 Traveller Discovery Quiz

The Discovery Quiz is the primary structured discovery tool. It is presented as a series of short, visually supported questions that guide the traveller from vague intention to specific resonance. It should take no more than three minutes to complete and should feel like a conversation, not a survey.

Question 1: How Would You Like to Feel?

Six emotional states are presented as visual cards, each carrying a photograph that embodies the mood. The traveller selects one.

Still	Quieter than your daily life. A place that removes pace rather than adding it.
Moved	Emotionally connected to a place, its history, or the people in it.
Adventurous	Physically engaged, exploring terrain that requires something from you.
Connected	In meaningful conversation with local culture, craft, or community.
Restored	Returning to yourself through wellness, nature, or deliberate slowness.
Discovered	Finding places and moments that most travellers never encounter.

Question 2: How Do You Like to Experience a Place?

Slowly, letting it unfold	Fewer places, longer stays, time to understand a context before moving on
Actively, covering ground	A full itinerary, maximum reach across the island
Intimately, off the path	Avoiding crowds, seeking smaller and less-visited experiences
Culturally, through its history and people	Led by heritage, craft, community, and the stories that give places meaning

Question 3: What Pace Feels Right?

3-7 days	A focused visit. One region, understood properly.
8-14 days	A complete journey. Several regions, with time to breathe.
More than two weeks	An immersion. Sri Lanka at depth, on its own terms.

10.2 Mood-Based Discovery

Alongside the structured quiz, the platform offers a visual mood-based entry point for travellers who prefer to explore rather than answer questions. Travellers browse a curated gallery of atmospheric images grouped by mood and select the ones that resonate.

The platform reads the pattern of selections and generates an editorial response: "Based on what drew you in, there is a particular part of Sri Lanka you should know about first." This approach reaches travellers who are still forming their intentions and cannot yet answer structured questions accurately.

10.3 Travel Personality Archetypes

The platform recognises eight travel personality archetypes. Each archetype receives a curated set of experiences, destinations, and journal content tailored to their orientation. Archetypes are assigned based on quiz responses and are presented to the traveller as part of their discovery result.

The Contemplative	Seeks stillness, reflection, and environments that support inner clarity. Drawn to hill country, early mornings, silent temples, and unhurried coastal walks.
The Cultural Immersionist	Seeks deep engagement with local communities, craft traditions, culinary heritage, and the stories that give a place its particular character.
The Discreet Luxury Traveller	Seeks privacy, refinement, and exceptional service. Drawn to private villas, bespoke itineraries, and experiences that feel exclusive without performing exclusivity.
The Slow Wanderer	Seeks connection with a place at its own pace. Drawn to extended stays in one location, local relationships, and the texture of daily life.
The Thoughtful Explorer	Seeks discovery, specificity, and the satisfaction of finding something genuinely rare. Drawn to off-path destinations, knowledgeable guides, and honest travel writing.
The Wellness Seeker	Seeks physical and psychological restoration. Drawn to Ayurvedic retreats, coastal stillness, highland air, and experiences that prioritise recovery over activity.
The Heritage Traveller	Seeks historical context and the feeling of encountering something ancient. Drawn to the Cultural Triangle, colonial architecture, living religious sites, and the layers of Sri Lankan history.
The Nature Witness	Seeks encounter with the natural world on its own terms. Drawn to wildlife, endemic birdlife, coastal ecosystems, and experiences that require patience.

10.4 Preference Dimensions

Luxury Preferences

Privacy	Preference for private villas over hotel properties, exclusive access, minimal other guests
Service Style	Attentive and present versus discreet and invisible. Both are luxury. They are different luxuries.
Environment	Wild and natural versus refined and curated
Accommodation Scale	Intimate boutique (4-12 rooms) versus established resort (30-80 rooms)

Pace Preferences

Daily rhythm	Early mornings and quiet evenings versus flexible late starts
Activity level	Gentle and observational versus physically engaged
Transfer frequency	Preference for minimal movement between locations versus wider geographic coverage

Cultural Immersion Preferences

Depth of access	Preference for genuine community encounters versus respectful distance observation
Guidance	Expert-led interpretation versus independent discovery
Local integration	Experiences designed with local communities versus experiences curated for visitor comfort

10.5 Sample Traveller Journeys

Oliver Bennett: The Thoughtful Explorer

Quiz responses: "Discovered" as emotional goal, "Intimately, off the path" as experience style, "8-14 days" as duration.

Platform response: The system identifies Oliver as a Thoughtful Explorer archetype and presents a curated editorial introduction to three lesser-known destinations in Sri Lanka, each introduced through a specific detail rather than a general description. His journal feed is populated with articles about hidden places, specific cultural encounters, and essays that treat Sri Lanka with the same depth of attention he brings to his research.

Consultation stage: The consultant opens with a question about where Oliver has already been in Asia and what he found most meaningful. The proposal that follows addresses specific interests rather than offering a standard itinerary. The tone is that of a knowledgeable friend, not a service provider.

Charlotte Sinclair: The Luxury Seeker

Quiz responses: "Still" as emotional goal, "Slowly, letting it unfold" as experience style, "8-14 days" as duration.

Platform response: The system identifies Charlotte as a Discreet Luxury Traveller archetype and presents a curated introduction to Sri Lanka through the lens of exceptional private accommodation and restorative experience. No price information appears in the discovery phase. The emphasis is on quality of environment, service character, and the particular atmosphere of each property.

Consultation stage: The consultant acknowledges Charlotte's preference for stillness and privacy before introducing any specific property. The proposal includes detailed descriptions of the accommodation environment, the service philosophy of each property, and the specific experiences available to private guests. Pricing is introduced naturally within the context of the full proposal, not as a headline.

Amelia Carter: The Slow Traveller

Quiz responses: "Connected" as emotional goal, "Slowly, letting it unfold" as experience style, "More than two weeks" as duration.

Platform response: The system identifies Amelia as a Slow Wanderer archetype and presents a curated introduction to Sri Lanka through extended-stay experiences, community relationships, and the texture of daily life in specific regions. The journal content surfaced for Amelia emphasises essays about living in a place rather than visiting it.

Consultation stage: The consultant asks about Amelia's previous experience of extended travel and what she has found most valuable about staying somewhere long enough to understand it. The proposal that follows prioritises depth over breadth, featuring one or two anchor locations with a range of experiences within each, rather than a circuit of the island.

11 · Experience Architecture

The Experience Architecture maps every stage of the traveller's journey across the Royale Isles Lanka platform. Each stage has a defined purpose, an emotional goal, a UX goal, and a business goal. Understanding all four dimensions ensures that design and development decisions at each stage serve the traveller and the platform simultaneously.

Stage 1: Homepage

Dimension	Goal	Implementation
Emotional	Create the immediate sense of having arrived somewhere that was designed for a specific kind of person	Living photograph hero with single headline. No carousel. No promotional content. No urgency.
UX	Orient the traveller within the platform and invite exploration without directing it	Clear navigation. Editorial section sequence. Multiple pathways into deeper content.
Business	Establish brand quality and begin building the trust that will eventually lead to a consultation	No conversion pressure. Quality of experience builds long-term relationship value.

Stage 2: Traveller Discovery

Dimension	Goal	Implementation
Emotional	Make the traveller feel genuinely understood before anything has been recommended	The Discovery Quiz. Mood-based image selection. Editorial archetype reveal.
UX	Gather preference data in a way that feels like a conversation, not a form	Maximum 3 minutes. Visual choices over text inputs. Warm language throughout.
Business	Build a preference profile that enables more accurate and resonant recommendations	Data stored for consultation use. No visible profiling language.

Stage 3: Destination Explorer

Dimension	Goal	Implementation
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Emotional	Inspire curiosity about specific places through specific, honest description	Editorial destination pages. No star ratings. No comparative pricing. Sensory language.
UX	Enable exploration by region, experience type, or mood without requiring linear navigation	Multiple entry points. Map, mood, and category navigation. Related content surfacing.
Business	Deepen engagement with the platform's destination knowledge and build confidence in expertise	Depth of content signals authority. Specificity builds trust.

Stage 4: Interactive Map

Dimension	Goal	Implementation
Emotional	Give the traveller a sense of the geography and the relationships between places	Illustrated or editorial map aesthetic. Not a standard Google Maps embed. Curated, not comprehensive.
UX	Allow spatial exploration of Sri Lanka alongside editorial content	Clickable regions leading to destination pages. Journey route visualisation. Filtering by experience type.
Business	Increase time on platform. Encourage multi-destination exploration that naturally leads to consultation	Map engagement is a strong pre-consultation signal.

Stage 5: Experience Collections

Dimension	Goal	Implementation
Emotional	Make the traveller excited about the specific kind of experiences available, not just the destination	Curated experience categories. Rail journeys. Tea rituals. Wildlife encounters. Coastal wellness.
UX	Provide an experience-first navigation pathway as an alternative to destination-first navigation	Experience pages link naturally to relevant destinations and journal content.
Business	Surface the depth of curation and expertise that differentiates the platform from generalist competitors	Specificity and quality of experience content converts browsers into inquirers.

Stage 6: Journey Builder

Dimension	Goal	Implementation
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Emotional	Give the traveller a felt sense of their potential itinerary before committing to a consultation	Visual itinerary preview. Mood and tone, not logistics and timetables.
UX	Allow travellers to begin shaping a journey at their own pace before involving a human consultant	Drag-and-drop or selection-based builder. Save for later. No pricing at this stage.
Business	Capture journey intent data that enriches the consultation and reduces the consultative effort required	Journey Builder completion is the highest-quality consultation signal.

Stage 7: Consultation Request

Dimension	Goal	Implementation
Emotional	Make the traveller feel that beginning a conversation is a natural and comfortable next step	Warm, low-friction inquiry form. No form fields that feel intrusive. Playfair Display italic questions.
UX	Gather just enough context to enable a meaningful first response	Open text fields over dropdowns. Journey vision, timing, companions, preferred contact method.
Business	Begin the human consultation relationship with a clear picture of traveller intent	Form responses feed directly into consultant briefing. No automated itinerary responses.

Stage 8: Personal Proposal

Dimension	Goal	Implementation
Emotional	Make the traveller feel that the proposal was written specifically for them	Named greeting. Specific references to the inquiry. Distinctive voice. Editorial presentation.
UX	Present the proposal in a format that is engaging to read and easy to navigate	PDF or responsive web document. Visual itinerary overview. Detailed narrative for each element.
Business	Convert the consultation relationship into a confirmed journey	Quality of proposal is the primary conversion factor. Trust, not price.

Stage 9: Booking Support

Dimension	Goal	Implementation
Emotional	Maintain the quality of the relationship through the logistical stages of booking	Single point of contact. Proactive communication. Transparent process.

UX	Make the practical aspects of booking clear, efficient, and reassuring	Clear documentation. Payment process that feels secure and private. Accessible contact throughout.
Business	Complete the booking efficiently while setting expectations for the journey itself	Booking completion rate. Referral propensity. Post-booking satisfaction.

Stage 10: Post-Travel Storytelling

Dimension	Goal	Implementation
Emotional	Acknowledge the significance of what the traveller has experienced and invite them to share it	Personal message from the consultant after travel. Invitation to contribute to the journal if appropriate.
UX	Create a pathway for travellers to document and share their experience in a way that aligns with the brand voice	Curated story submission. Editorial support offered. Privacy respected as default.
Business	Generate authentic testimonial content. Build long-term loyalty. Create the conditions for referrals.	Traveller stories, when published, become the most credible content the platform has.

12 · Photography Strategy and Visual Storytelling

The photography strategy for Royale Isles Lanka is built around a four-level content hierarchy. Each level serves a distinct purpose and appears with a different frequency. Understanding when and why to use each level is as important as understanding the technical specifications of each image type.

Level 1: Atmosphere

The primary visual register of the brand. Landscapes, light, weather conditions, the feeling of a place at a specific time of day or season. These images carry no human presence. They are the place before anyone arrives.

When to Use

Hero sections. Homepage. Section openers. Destination cover images. Living photography sequences. Background environments for text-heavy pages.

What Makes a Strong Level 1 Image

Light quality	Golden hour, blue hour, overcast diffusion. Light that has a specific character, not simply adequate exposure.
Depth	Layers from foreground to far distance. An image the eye continues to explore.
Stillness	No wind-blurred vegetation, no motion blur in clouds unless deliberately atmospheric. The image should feel composed.
Sri Lankan specificity	An image that could only be this place. Not a generic landscape that might belong to anywhere.
Harmony with palette	Colours that sit naturally within the brand palette. Deep greens, warm ambers, stone, mist.

Level 2: Luxury Moments

The second register: the physical details of a remarkable experience. Private villas, verandahs overlooking misty hills, candlelit dinners, a first-class train compartment window, a tea ritual in a plantation bungalow, the still water of a private pool at dusk.

When to Use

Accommodation pages. Experience cards. Journal articles about specific properties or moments. Partnership and recommendation sections.

What Makes a Strong Level 2 Image

Intimacy of scale	Close enough to feel the texture of the experience. Far enough to establish context.
Evidence of quality	Fine materials, considered arrangement, the absence of anything accidental or careless.
No visible branding	Property and brand names should not be legible in the image. The experience speaks for itself.
Absence of people or presence implied	A set table with one chair pulled out slightly. A cup of tea with a book beside it. The suggestion of a person, not their presence.

Level 3: Human Presence

The third register: a traveller in a place, engaged with it on their own terms. Reading on a verandah. Standing at the edge of a viewpoint. Walking through a quiet village at dawn. Always from behind, in silhouette, or at sufficient distance that no individual is identifiable.

When to Use

Editorial content. Journey-builder sections. Destination descriptions where the sense of a person experiencing a place adds resonance. Use sparingly within hero sections.

What Makes a Strong Level 3 Image

Anonymity	The viewer should see themselves in the image, not observe a specific person.
Engagement with place, not camera	The subject is looking at the view, reading the book, feeling the rain. Never performing for documentation.
Appropriate scale	The person should be small relative to the environment. The landscape is primary. The human presence is contextual.

Level 4: Human Interaction

The fourth register: genuine encounters between a traveller and the people or culture of Sri Lanka. A craftsman demonstrating a traditional skill. A guide explaining something specific. A market vendor and a traveller in conversation. Used with significant restraint and only where authenticity can be guaranteed.

When to Use

Cultural immersion sections of the platform. Journal articles about specific experiences or communities. Use only where the interaction depicted was genuine and the subject's consent was fully informed.

The Critical Distinction in Human Interaction Photography

THE STAGED SMILE VERSUS THE HONEST MOMENT

A traveller smiling broadly at a market vendor while holding a piece of fruit for the camera is tourism photography. It documents the performance of an encounter rather than the encounter itself. The

vendor's expression is often politely accommodating rather than genuine. The traveller's expression is directed at the camera, not at the person they are supposedly engaging with. A traveller standing at the edge of a market stall, quietly observing a craftsperson work, without being noticed: this is an honest image. It captures the quality of genuine attention. The viewer is invited to observe both the craftsperson and the traveller's response to them. Royale Isles Lanka uses the second image. The first image, however technically accomplished, belongs to a different kind of travel brand.

12.1 Photography Approval Criteria

Before any image is approved for use on the platform, it must pass four questions.

1. Does this image create a feeling before it describes anything?
2. Does it contain a depth that rewards more than a brief look?
3. Could it belong to any destination, or is it unmistakably Sri Lankan?
4. Does it align with the emotional register of the page or section it will appear in?

An image that fails any of these questions is not approved, regardless of its technical quality.

12.2 Alt Text Standards

Alt text on this platform is written to the same standard as visible copy. It should be specific, atmospheric, and honest.

Correct	"Mist gathering over the Ella Gap at dawn, viewed from a private verandah in the hill country"
Incorrect	"Sri Lanka landscape photo"
Correct	"A lantern burning on the steps of an ancient temple corridor at dusk, no visitors in sight"
Incorrect	"Temple image"
Correct	"Steam rising from a porcelain cup of Ceylon tea on a wooden table overlooking misty tea terraces"
Incorrect	"Tea"

13 · Information Architecture

The information architecture of Royale Isles Lanka is organised around the traveller's journey rather than a conventional website hierarchy. The primary question it answers is not "where is this content?" but "where is the traveller in their discovery process, and what do they need next?"

13.1 Complete Sitemap

Homepage	Living photography hero · Philosophy statement · Traveller Discovery entry point · Featured experiences (3 maximum) · Journal excerpt · Why Royale Isles Lanka (3 values) · Destination gateway · Consultation invitation
About Royale Isles Lanka	Our Philosophy · Who We Are · Our Approach to Curation · Service Commitments · The Team
Traveller Discovery	Discovery Quiz · Mood-Based Discovery · Travel Archetype Reveal · Personalised Content Feed
Destinations: Hill Country	Editorial destination page · Region highlights · Recommended experiences · Featured accommodation · Linked journal articles
Destinations: South Coast	Editorial destination page · Region highlights · Recommended experiences · Featured accommodation · Linked journal articles
Destinations: Ancient Kingdoms	Editorial destination page · Region highlights · Recommended experiences · Heritage context · Linked journal articles
Destinations: East Coast	Editorial destination page · Region highlights · Recommended experiences · Featured accommodation · Linked journal articles
Destinations: Wildlife and Nature	Editorial destination page · National parks · Season guides · Recommended experiences · Linked journal articles
Destinations: Hidden Places	Editorially curated lesser-known destinations · Discovery-first presentation · No standard tourism framing
Experiences: Wellness	Ayurvedic retreats · Coastal restoration · Highland wellness · Property recommendations
Experiences: Slow Travel	Extended stay options · Community connections · Daily life immersion · Property recommendations
Experiences: Heritage	Ancient Kingdoms circuit · Colonial architecture · Living religious sites · Expert-guided options
Experiences: Culinary	Tea culture · Traditional cooking · Coastal seafood · Market encounters
Experiences: Rail Journeys	Kandy to Ella route · First-class options · Station context · Seasonal considerations
Experiences: Wildlife	Leopard country · Whale watching · Endemic birdlife · Elephant encounters · Ethical framework

Interactive Discovery Map	Illustrated island map · Clickable regions · Journey route visualisation · Experience type filtering · Seasonal layer
Journal: Stories	Long-form narrative articles about specific places, moments, or encounters
Journal: Guides	Practical, expert-written guidance on specific aspects of Sri Lanka travel
Journal: Reflections	Essays on the experience of travel itself and what makes Sri Lanka particular
Consultation	Inquiry form · WhatsApp contact option · What to expect from the consultation · Response time commitment
Discovery Guide Request	Request for a curated PDF guide tailored to the traveller's interests, shared by email
FAQ	Honest answers to common questions. Visa, climate, transport, timing, and frequently misunderstood aspects of Sri Lanka travel.
Contact	General enquiries · Partnership enquiries · Press and media · Emergency contact for travelling clients

13.2 Navigation Between Pages

Navigation within Royale Isles Lanka is designed to feel exploratory rather than transactional. The traveller is never directed to a single path. Multiple entry points to the same content exist so that different types of travellers can reach what they need via the route that feels most natural.

Homepage to Discovery	Via "Begin Your Journey" CTA in hero section, or via "Discover" in primary navigation
Homepage to Destinations	Via the destination gateway section (visual region selector) or via "Destinations" in primary navigation
Homepage to Journal	Via featured journal excerpt in homepage section sequence, or via "Journal" in primary navigation
Discovery to Destinations	Automatic content surfacing based on quiz responses. System suggests 2-3 most relevant destinations.
Discovery to Experiences	Automatic content surfacing based on travel style and pace preferences
Destination to Journal	Each destination page surfaces 2-3 related journal articles in context
Experience to Consultation	Each experience page includes a soft consultation invitation contextualised to that experience type
Journal to Consultation	Each journal article closes with a single-sentence consultation invitation when appropriate
Map to Destinations	Clicking a map region opens the corresponding destination page in an editorial panel

13.3 Homepage Section-to-Depth Connections

Each section of the homepage connects directly to a deeper layer of content. The homepage functions as both an orientation experience and a navigation system.

Hero section	Connects to Traveller Discovery via primary CTA
Philosophy statement	Connects to About Royale Isles Lanka, specifically the Our Philosophy page
Featured experiences	Each of the three experience cards links to the corresponding Experience page
Journal excerpt	Links to the full Journal article and to the Journal index
Why Royale Isles Lanka	Links to About Royale Isles Lanka, specifically the Service Commitments page
Destination gateway	Each region card links to the corresponding Destination page
Consultation invitation	Links to the Consultation page

14 · Accessibility

Accessibility is not compliance. It is the expression of the belief that an exceptional experience should be available to everyone who seeks it. The care required to ensure every typographic combination meets contrast requirements, every image carries thoughtful alt text, and every form field is clearly labelled is the same care that the brand promises in every other dimension.

"An accessible platform is a trustworthy platform. Accessibility is where the brand promise is either kept or broken at the level of implementation."

14.1 Standards Compliance

Primary Standard	WCAG 2.1 AA: the global benchmark. All content must meet this standard before launch.
Target Standard	WCAG 2.1 AAA where feasible. The colour palette already exceeds AAA for all primary text combinations.
European Accessibility Act	Compliance required for EU audience. WCAG 2.1 AA is the path to EAA alignment.
ADA (United States)	WCAG 2.1 AA provides a strong basis for ADA compliance for US-based travellers.

14.2 Implementation Checklist

Colour Contrast	All text combinations meet minimum 4.5:1 (body text) and 3:1 (large text). Primary combinations exceed AAA.
Keyboard Navigation	All interactive elements fully operable by keyboard. Tab order mirrors logical reading sequence. Skip-to-content link on all pages.
Focus Indicators	2-3px solid outline in British Racing Green on light surfaces, white on dark surfaces. Minimum 3:1 contrast between indicator and background.
Alternative Text	All images carry descriptive, atmospherically considered alt text. Decorative images use empty alt="". Complex visuals include extended descriptions.
Responsive Design	Fully functional at all viewport sizes. Content preserved at 200% browser zoom. Touch targets minimum 44x44px.
Screen Reader Support	Semantic HTML structure. Correct heading hierarchy H1 through H3. Navigation landmarks. ARIA attributes where native semantics are insufficient.
Form Accessibility	All fields have visible labels. Placeholder supplements, never replaces. Error messages are descriptive and recovery-oriented. Required fields clearly indicated.

Captions and Transcripts	All video includes accurate, time-synced captions. Auto-generated captions reviewed and corrected before publication.
Multimedia Control	Background video controllable by the user. Autoplay audio disabled by default. Pause and stop controls are keyboard-accessible.
Typography Minimums	Body text minimum 16px Inter. Playfair Display minimum 20px. Line height minimum 1.5 for body content. Measure 60-75 characters per line.
Motion	All animations respect prefers-reduced-motion. No content flashes more than three times per second.
Link Purpose	All links describe their destination. No "click here" or "read more" without contextual clarity.

15 · Voice and Tone

Tone of voice is not a copywriting decision. It is a brand decision. It is present in every word on every page: the headline, the caption, the button label, the WhatsApp reply, the error message. The way the platform speaks either builds or undermines trust with every traveller who reads it.

The voice of Royale Isles Lanka is: warm but not gushing. Knowledgeable but not condescending. Precise but not clinical. Calm but not flat. Personal but not familiar. Confident but not promotional.

15.1 The Five Voice Personalities

The Trusted Guide: Knows without needing to prove it	The platform never shows off its knowledge. It shares it selectively, the way that a person who has been somewhere many times will share something specific rather than comprehensive. It says "most visitors miss this" rather than "here are fifteen things to do."
The Thoughtful Host: Creates comfort before asking for commitment	A great host does not ask what you would like to drink before you have sat down. The platform creates the conditions for comfort before it asks anything of the traveller. It gives context, warmth, and reassurance before it asks for a name or a preference.
The Quiet Curator: Selects carefully instead of overwhelming	The quietest curators are also the most respected. They do not present everything that exists. Three exceptional options over thirty adequate ones. Sequenced revelation over comprehensive presentation.
The Experienced Traveller: Speaks from lived understanding, not marketing language	The platform has been there, in the sense of someone who has arrived at a place early in the morning before other people appear and understood something about it that cannot be described in a tour itinerary.
The Attentive Concierge: Pays attention without becoming intrusive	The finest concierge you have ever encountered probably did not ask many questions. They noticed. They remembered. They made a suggestion at exactly the right moment that made you feel seen without feeling watched.

15.2 We Sound Like / We Do Not Sound Like

We Sound Like	We Do Not Sound Like
"Some places reveal themselves slowly. This is one of them."	"Book now before availability runs out."
"Tell us how you like to travel. We'll take it from there."	"Exclusive deals available today."
"The best journeys rarely begin with an itinerary."	"Best price guaranteed. Limited time offer."
"There are moments here that most people never find. We know where they are."	"Don't miss out on this incredible experience!"

"Your journey begins before you arrive."	"Fill in the form below to get started."
"Take your time. We're not going anywhere."	"We offer the widest range of Sri Lanka packages."
"We've been waiting to share this with someone like you."	"Click here for more information."

15.3 Grammatical and Stylistic Rules

Always

- Begin with the feeling before the fact
- Use active voice in preference to passive
- Choose the specific over the general: "a particular morning in November" not "a day"
- Edit until only what matters remains
- One precise phrase over three approximate ones

Never

- Use exclamation marks
- Use "incredible", "amazing", "unforgettable", "world-class", or "luxury" as descriptors. Show these qualities instead.
- Use urgency framing: "Only a few spots left" or "Book before it's too late"
- Use second person to pressure: "You won't want to miss this"

Sri Lankan Storytelling

When writing about Sri Lanka, prioritise specificity over generality. "The Ella Gap in November, when the mist is thick enough to feel" over "the beautiful Sri Lankan landscape." Sensory particulars over visual summaries. The unexpected truth over the expected beauty.

16 · Content Guidelines

16.1 Narrative Architecture

Every page of the platform has a narrative arc. Every section has a role within that arc. Content is structured as a journey: it begins with an arrival moment that places the traveller there, moves through the experience of being in a place, and ends with a departure feeling.

Opening	Places the traveller before describing anything. Sets emotional register. Playfair Display headline. Maximum 12 words. Pure feeling.
Middle	The experience of being in a place. Sensory specifics. Cultural depth. Personal moments. Two to four paragraphs. Each paragraph earns the next.
Closing	The emotion the place leaves behind. Not a summary, but a resonance. Often a pull quote or a single sentence that works as an open door.

16.2 Content Pacing

- Maximum three consecutive paragraphs before a visual break
- Pull quotes or whitespace sections every 600-800 words of long-form content
- Image-to-text ratio in editorial sections: approximately 40% image space
- Never more than two heavy sections in sequence. Light after dark, stillness after depth.

16.3 Destination Content Framework

Opening Hook	1 sentence. Sensory and specific. Sets the register. Example: "There are places in Sri Lanka that require a particular kind of quiet to enter. This is one of them."
Character	1-2 paragraphs. The personality of the place: what makes it unlike anywhere else. No lists of attractions.
The Moment	1 paragraph. The specific experience that defines it. The one thing, not the ten things.
For You If	3-4 lines. Honest description of who this place is for. Disqualifying language is more trustworthy than inclusive marketing.
What to Know	Practical information: best time to visit, how to arrive, what to expect. Honest. Specific. No destination copy clichés.

16.4 Journal Standards

The Journal is the editorial heart of the platform. It is not a blog. It is a curated collection of written explorations produced with the care and specificity of a print editorial publication.

- Minimum 800 words, maximum 1,500 words per article
- Always in the voice of someone who has been there. No aggregated, generic destination copy.
- One primary photograph per article (hero) plus maximum three inline images
- Pull quote selected from within the article. Never invented as a summary.
- No "Top 10" lists. Narratives only.
- Consistency over volume: two exceptional articles per month over eight adequate ones

16.5 SEO and Search Copy

Search optimisation must not compromise the brand voice. Keywords are embedded within genuinely useful, well-written sentences, never written around.

- Meta titles: brand voice first. "Sri Lanka, Unhurried | Royale Isles Lanka" rather than "Best Luxury Sri Lanka Tours 2026"
- Meta descriptions: treat as the first sentence of a conversation, not a keyword container
- Heading hierarchy follows narrative logic, not keyword density

17 · Luxury Travel UX Guidelines

Luxury travel UX operates by different rules than conventional e-commerce or SaaS design. The patterns that maximise conversion in transactional contexts, such as urgency, scarcity, and progressive commitment, actively damage the luxury brand relationship.

17.1 Luxury versus Standard UX

Standard UX Approach	Luxury UX Approach
Minimise friction to reduce drop-off	Create appropriate considered friction. Deliberate choices feel more valuable.
Show all options to maximise engagement	Curate ruthlessly. Fewer options signal better judgment.
Urgency and scarcity increase conversion	Urgency destroys trust. Luxury buyers are never rushed.
Personalisation via tracking and retargeting	Personalisation via conversation and attentiveness
CTAs are direct and action-oriented	CTAs are invitations, never directives
More information reduces purchase anxiety	Curated information, well-timed, builds confidence without overwhelm
Social proof via numbers and star ratings	Social proof via specific, editorial, first-person, named testimonials

17.2 The Consultation Model

Royale Isles Lanka operates a consultation model, not an e-commerce model. The traveller explores, discovers, and builds an emotional relationship with a destination before being invited to begin a conversation with a human expert.

Stage 1: Discovery	The traveller arrives and explores freely. No login required. No forms. No tracking pop-ups. The platform gives before it asks.
Stage 2: Resonance	Something specific creates a connection. The traveller slows down and reads more deeply.
Stage 3: Recognition	The traveller recognises themselves in the platform. Personalisation options emerge naturally.
Stage 4: Invitation	The traveller is invited, not prompted, to begin a conversation. The inquiry feels like the beginning of a relationship.
Stage 5: Consultation	A human expert responds. The relationship deepens. The itinerary emerges from understanding, not from a template.

17.3 Performance Standards for Luxury

Time on Site	Target 3-8 minutes average. A traveller who spends 3 minutes reading a single journal article is more valuable than one who clicks through 8 pages in 90 seconds.
Inquiry Quality	The depth and specificity of inquiries matters more than volume. A detailed, contextual inquiry from someone who has spent 20 minutes on the platform is the goal.
Return Visits	VVIP travellers research slowly over weeks. Multiple return visits before inquiry are expected and healthy.
Scroll Depth	High scroll depth on long-form content indicates genuine engagement. Target: 80% or more of journal readers reach the end.
WhatsApp Response Time	Under 2 hours during operating hours. Tone must match platform voice from the first message.

*The homepage is the arrival experience.
It should feel like entering a room that was designed for you.*

18 · Homepage Guidelines

The homepage is the most important single page on the platform. It sets the emotional register for everything that follows. It must, within the first scroll, communicate: this was made for someone like you.

18.1 The Hero Section

Image	One image only. Sri Lanka landscape: tea country, coastline, or ancient stone. Portrait of stillness, not activity. No human figures as the primary subject.
Movement	One micro-animation: mist, steam, candlelight, or gentle water. Duration: 10-16 second loop. Imperceptible at first glance.
Headline	Playfair Display / 64-72px / White / Centred or left-aligned Maximum 10 words. Emotional, not descriptive. Example: "Sri Lanka. For Those Who Already Know." Example: "Some Islands Change the Way You Travel."
Sub-headline	Inter / 18px / opacity 0.8 white / 1 line only Example: "Private luxury travel experiences for discerning travellers"
CTA	One invitation. Not "Book Now". Not "Explore". Example: "Begin Your Journey" British Racing Green button or ghost white button depending on image brightness.
Navigation	Transparent over hero image. Transitions to British Racing Green on scroll.

18.2 Homepage Section Sequence

- Hero: living photograph with headline and single CTA
- Philosophy statement: 2-3 sentences on who this platform is for. Playfair Display italic. Quiet and assured.
- Traveller Discovery entry: "How would you like to feel on this journey?" Interactive preference prompt or editorial gateway.
- Featured experiences: 3 cards maximum. Feelings, not destinations. "Stillness in the Hill Country" · "The Coast, Before it Wakes" · "Ancient Sri Lanka, Privately"
- Journal excerpt: 1 recent editorial article, presented as a full editorial spread. Not a card. Not a thumbnail.
- Why Royale Isles Lanka: 3 values presented as short editorial statements. Not bullet points. Not icons. Words.
- Destination gateway: visual map or curated region selector. 6 regions maximum.
- Consultation invitation: the softest possible CTA. "When you're ready to talk, we're here." A WhatsApp prompt or a single sentence with a link, not a form.

18.3 Homepage Rules

- No hero carousel or image slider
- No pricing on the homepage

- No testimonial sliders with star ratings
- No "popular packages" or "best sellers"
- No newsletter sign-up pop-up, ever
- No live chat that initiates unprompted
- No countdown timers or "last minute availability"
- No partner logo wall

19 · Design System Governance

A design system is only as valuable as the discipline applied to maintaining it. As the Royale Isles Lanka platform grows, new features will be proposed, new content types will emerge, and new team members will join. This section establishes the processes and standards that protect the quality and consistency of the brand experience over time.

19.1 Design Review Process

Every new design element, from a single component to a full new page, must pass through the following evaluation before implementation.

Step 1: Philosophy Check	Does this addition serve the traveller before it serves anything else? Does it align with the five brand pillars: Elegant, Private, Sophisticated, Personal, and Experience? If it fails this check, redesign before proceeding.
Step 2: Principle Check	Run the addition against the seven design principles. Pay particular attention to Principle I (Guide, Do Not Overwhelm) and Principle VII (Attention as a Gift). Both are frequently violated by well-intentioned additions.
Step 3: Consistency Check	Does this addition use only the approved colour system, typography system, spacing scale, and component library? Any deviation requires explicit documentation of the exception and its justification.
Step 4: Accessibility Check	All colour combinations, interactive elements, and form fields must be verified against the accessibility requirements in Section 14 before sign-off.
Step 5: Voice Check	All copy associated with the new addition, including labels, error messages, empty states, and confirmations, must be reviewed against the voice guidelines in Section 15.

19.2 Photography Approval Process

All images used on the platform must be approved against the photography hierarchy in Section 12 before publication. The following process applies.

13. The photographer or content team submits images with context: what level of the hierarchy this image is intended for, and where on the platform it will be used.
14. The approving reviewer applies the four approval questions from Section 12.1.
15. Images that pass are added to the approved asset library with appropriate metadata.
16. Images that fail are returned with specific feedback against the approval criteria, not general aesthetic opinion.
17. No image from an external stock library is approved without exception sign-off from the lead designer or creative director. Stock imagery is a last resort, never a first choice.

19.3 Copywriting Standards

All copy published on the platform must comply with the following standards.

- Every piece of copy is reviewed against the voice guidelines in Section 15 before publication
- Copy that uses urgency language, promotional framing, or generic destination descriptions is rejected at the review stage, not edited post-publication
- Destination copy must include at least one piece of specific, non-generic information that could only apply to that place
- Journal articles must be reviewed by someone who has personal knowledge of the subject matter, or must clearly state the basis of the writer's knowledge
- All microcopy, including error messages, loading states, and confirmations, must be reviewed against the microcopy reference in Section 06 before any new feature launches

19.4 Component Versioning

When a component is updated or a new component is added to the library, the following documentation is required.

Component name	Descriptive, not functional. "The Quiet Card" not "card-type-2"
Version number	Major.Minor format. Major for breaking changes, Minor for refinements.
Rationale	One paragraph explaining why this component exists and what emotional job it performs
Usage context	Where it appears on the platform and under what conditions
Prohibited uses	Explicitly listed cases where this component should not be used
Accessibility notes	Any specific accessibility considerations for this component

19.5 Evaluating New Features Against Brand Philosophy

As the platform grows, new features will be proposed. Each must be evaluated against the following questions before being approved for development.

- Does this feature serve the traveller, or does it primarily serve a business metric?
- Does it create calm or urgency? Does it give or ask?
- Does it require the traveller to provide something (data, action, commitment) before it gives them something of value?
- Would the traveller feel respected, guided, and attended to by this feature, or would they feel tracked, directed, or pressured?
- Does it introduce any visual element, language pattern, or interaction that contradicts the existing design system?
- Has it been tested with the three traveller personas: Oliver Bennett, Charlotte Sinclair, and Amelia Carter? Would each of them feel that it was made with their interests in mind?

A feature that passes these questions is approved for development. A feature that fails any one of them is returned for reconsideration. A feature that fails multiple questions is not implemented in its current form.

19.6 Brand Consistency Checks

At regular intervals, the platform should be audited for brand consistency. The following elements should be reviewed.

Colour audit	Verify that all implemented colour values match the approved palette. Particular attention to Charcoal Black (#1A1A1A) and Warm Ivory Silk (#FBF9F5), which are frequently overridden by default browser or framework styles.
Typography audit	Verify that all typography uses only Playfair Display and Inter in the specified sizes and weights. Check that Inter is used for all body text and UI elements, not Playfair Display at small sizes.
Voice audit	Review all new copy added since the last audit against the voice guidelines. Identify and correct any use of urgency language, promotional phrasing, or generic description.
Photography audit	Review all images added since the last audit against the photography hierarchy. Identify any stock imagery or images that do not meet the approval criteria.
Accessibility audit	Run automated accessibility checks and supplement with manual keyboard navigation testing. Log any new failures and address them within the current development cycle.

“What is being built here is not a website. It is a way of helping a particular kind of traveller find an experience that will change them. The responsibility of that introduction, the weight of doing it honestly, beautifully, and with genuine feeling, is what this document is ultimately about.”